

**BOUNCING
FORWARD**

DEDICATION

In memory of my late son

Hikmat

Whose name means Wisdom in Arabic.

He earned it — just not in the way any of us expected.

Contents

Foreword	01
Introduction	03
Chapter 1: <i>The Pillars that propel you</i>	05
Chapter 2: <i>The 4-Element Framework</i>	08
Element 1: Resilience <i>Weathering the Storms of Adversity</i>	10
Element 2: Adaptability <i>Navigating the Rapids of Change</i>	15
Element 3: Optimism <i>Lighting the Path Through the Darkness</i>	20
Element 4: Support <i>Weaving a Net of Collective Strength</i>	25
Chapter 3: <i>The 4-Step Model</i>	30
Step 1: Accept <i>Embracing the Inevitable</i>	31
Step 2: Reflect <i>Uncovering Insights from Setbacks</i>	37
Step 3: Imagine <i>Defining the Path Forward</i>	42
Step 4: Take Action <i>Catalyzing Change Through Initiative</i>	48
Conclusion	72
About the author	74

Chapter 4:	54
<i>Assessment & Personal Action Plan</i>	
Conclusion	74
About the Author	76

FOREWORD

FOREWORD

There is a phone call you never forget. It doesn't matter when it comes. A Tuesday afternoon. A Friday morning. The middle of a meeting. But when it comes, your life splits. Before the call. After the call. Two different worlds. You know this. That's why you're reading this book. Maybe the call has already come for you. Maybe the loss arrived differently—a diagnosis, a conversation, a morning you woke up and understood that something irreplaceable was gone. The form is always different. What it does to you is always the same. It removes the floor. I will not tell you this is easy. It is not. But I will tell you something I learned the hard way: inside the darkest loss, something can be built. Not instead of the pain. Because of it. This book is about that building.

Bouncing Forward is not a five-step plan to eliminate suffering. Life doesn't work that way. The ideas here came from real life. From a hospital in Amman. From a friend who appeared after forty years and said exactly what I needed to hear. From building 1,200 playgrounds across Jordan, turning setbacks into action, loss into legacy. I share this not because my story is unique. I share it because in some essential way, it is yours too.

“Not going back to who you were. Going forward to who you are capable of becoming.”

This is what Bouncing Forward is about. Turn the page. Let's Begin.

INTRODUCTION

INTRODUCTION

The call came at 2 am. Before I picked up, I already knew. You develop a sense for it. Something in the silence before someone speaks tells you whether what follows will change everything. This changed everything.

My son Hikmat — seventeen years old, full of life, at the edge of adulthood — had been struck by a car in Amman. The driver fled. My wife and I raced to the hospital. She wept. I prayed. Both of us suspended between hope and its opposite.

“I know this sounds like the kind of sentence you read in a book and then quietly set aside, unconvinced. That is exactly why I wrote this book. Not to offer you a theory. To show you the road.”

I didn't know it then — but in that hospital, in the days that followed, and in the years of work that came after — something was being given to me. Not instead of the pain. Alongside it. A direction. A purpose. A reason to keep building when everything in me wanted to stop.

I call it Bouncing Forward. Forward means through. It means setbacks do not get the last word. It means the worst thing that ever happened to you becomes, over time, the very thing that gives your life its fullest meaning. Three years after Hikmat's death, the Hikmat Road Safety Program had built over 1,200 playgrounds across Jordan, marked 260 schools in high-risk zones, and identified 1,800 dangerous locations on our roads. Hikmat did not die for nothing.

This book gives you two groups of tools. The 4-Element Framework — your compass: Resilience, Adaptability, Optimism, and Support. Four lights that are always burning inside you. The brighter you keep them, the clearer your way forward. The 4-Step Model — your path: Accept, Reflect, Imagine and Action. A sequence I followed — roughly, imperfectly — after losing Hikmat. Use what works. Set aside what doesn't. This is a compass, not a cage. Let's find your direction.

Chapter 1

THE PILARS THAT PROPEL YOU

Imagine a forest. Not the well-lit kind with signs at every junction. A real forest—ancient, dense, full of shadows. The kind where the trees grow so close you have to turn sideways to pass between them. This is your life after a significant loss. After a failure that redefines you. After the phone call that splits the world in two. You are standing at the edge. Somewhere on the other side—you can't see it yet, but you feel it—is the person you are capable of becoming. The question is how to cross. I've crossed this forest. Not cleanly. Not quickly. Not without losing my way. But I crossed it. And what carried me through wasn't luck or strength of character. It was two things. A compass. And a path.

“Vision without action is a daydream. Action without vision is a nightmare.”

The Two Tools That Guide The Journey

After losing Hikmat, I realized I had been building these tools for years without knowing it. The compass doesn't tell you where you're going. It tells you which direction is forward—even when the trees are too dense to see, even when the light is gone, even when your mind tells you that stopping is the only option. Without it, you circle. With it, you move.

The path doesn't carry you. It marks a sequence—one foot, then the next—so that when your mind wants to stop, your feet know what to do. Without it, you stand still, waiting for a moment of readiness that may never arrive. With it, you begin. These two tools can be learned. They are not gifts some people are born with and others are not. They are built through deliberate practice.

The 4-Element Framework is your compass. Four elements—Resilience, Adaptability, Optimism, and Support—function like four lights always burning inside you. The brighter you keep each one, the clearer your way forward will be.

The 4-Step Model is your path. Four steps—Accept, Reflect, Imagine, and Action—trace the sequence I followed after losing Hikmat. Not perfectly. Not in a straight line. But intentionally, one foot in front of the other, rather than simply enduring.

BOUNCING FORWARD

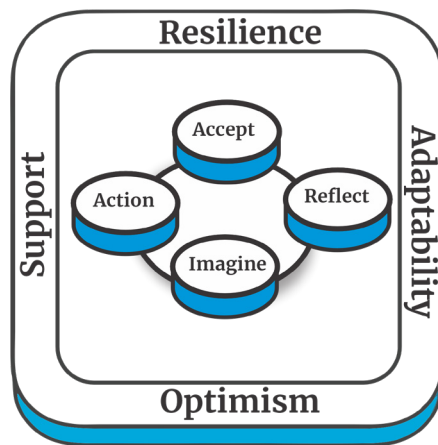
The chapters that follow go deep into each of these. You'll find honest descriptions of what each element looks like in the hardest days—not the polished version, but the real one.

You'll find the steps laid out with space to breathe, real stories from people who have walked versions of this road, and questions designed to help you find your own footing. Use what works. Set aside what doesn't. This is a compass, not a cage.

"The compass doesn't tell you where you're going."

Grounded in Belief

Beneath all of this—carrying all of this—is faith. I am a Muslim educated in a Catholic school. I have travelled to ninety countries and sat with people of every belief and tradition. In all that traveling, I have found one truth that crosses every border: the person who knows they are not facing the dark alone can endure almost anything. The compass and the path are practical tools. Faith is the ground they rest on. Now let's learn how to use them.



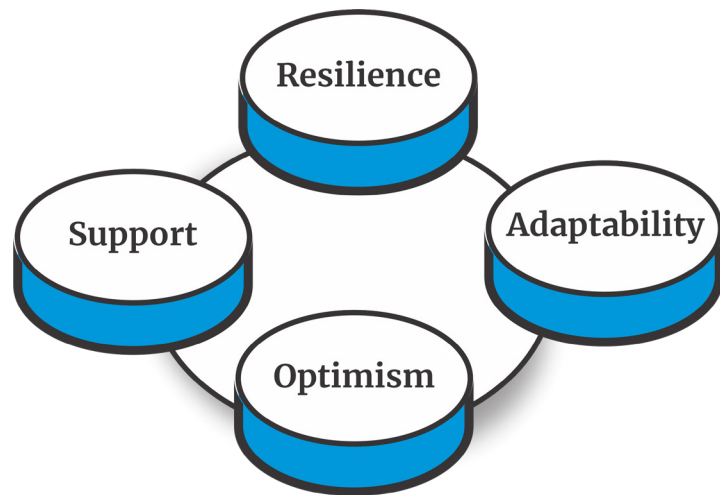
Chapter 2

THE 4-ELEMENT FRAMEWORK

BOUNCING FORWARD

Life is marked by storms that test our resilience, shake our foundations, and leave us feeling adrift. Our identity is not shaped by the existence of those storms. It is shaped by the choices we make while navigating through them. The four elements—Resilience, Adaptability, Optimism, and Support—are not a sequence to be followed in order. Think of them as four lights always burning inside you. The brighter you keep each one, the clearer your way forward will be.

“Our identity is not shaped by the existence of those storms. It is shaped by the choices we make while navigating through them.”



Element one

RESILIENCE

Weathering the storms of adversity

ELEMENT ONE: RESILIENCE

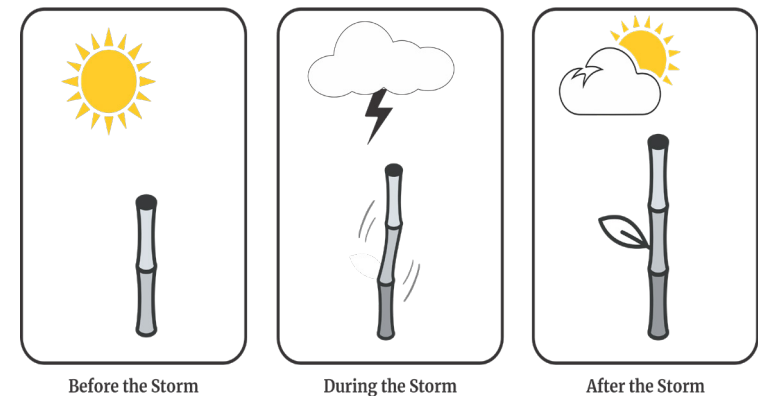
I was not prepared for grief to arrive in layers. The first is shock—a strange, merciful numbness that carries you through the phone call, the hospital corridor, the unimaginable conversations. The second is the realization that life continues. The sun comes up. The kettle boils. The world has not paused. In those first days after Hikmat’s death, I held onto the smallest things. His laugh.

The way he moved in a room. What I did not do—and this is the thing I want you to understand—is fall. Not completely. Not finally. Somewhere beneath the setbacks, something refused to break. Something kept looking for solid ground, even when the ground kept moving.

“Resilience is the unexpected light that emerges in the darkest times, transforming personal tragedy into shared purpose and a renewed direction.”

“Fostering Strength From Hikmat’s Legacy”

Think of a bamboo tree in a storm. It bends almost parallel to the ground under fierce wind. Then the storm passes. The bamboo slowly, patiently, returns upright. No drama. No performance. Just the deep structural knowledge that bending is not breaking. That is what resilience looks like from the inside.



Building Resilience: Five Honest Truths

- **Let the setbacks be setbacks:** The most damaging thing we do in the face of loss is rush through it—medicate it, distract it, perform recovery before moving through the pain. Resilience is built by walking through suffering at a sustainable pace, with your eyes open.
- **Find the one sentence that holds you:** In my darkest moments, mine was “Praise be to God.” Not because I felt grateful. Because it was an anchor. It kept me tethered to something larger than my own agony. Find your sentence.
- **Let people in:** A visitor I hadn’t seen for forty years arrived at the hospital and said exactly what my heart needed to hear. The most resilient people I know are not the ones who need no one—they are the ones who know how to receive.
- **Look for the purpose hiding in the pain:** I could not see it in the first days. But the question itself—“what can this become?”—kept me oriented forward rather than frozen in place.
- **Remember what you have already survived:** You are here, reading these words. Every difficult thing that has ever come for you has not had the final word. That is evidence. Let it be evidence.

A Story of Resilience: Malala Yousafzai

On October 9, 2012, a fifteen-year-old girl boarded a school bus in Pakistan’s Swat Valley. Men stopped the bus. One of them asked for Malala Yousafzai by name. She was shot in the head at point-blank range. She survived. When she was well enough to speak—well enough to choose what she would do next—she did not choose silence. She chose amplification.

“They thought that the bullets would silence us. But they failed.”

That is resilience in its fullest expression. Not merely surviving what was aimed at your destruction — but using the fact of your survival as the very source of your power.

Reflect on Resilience

- When was the last time you turned a failure into a stepping stone? What did you learn about yourself in the process?
- Have you ever felt like giving up but didn’t? What kept you going, and how did you feel when you came out the other side?
- Can you think of a time when something went terribly wrong, yet led to an unexpected opportunity? How did that change your perspective?

The Difference Between Bending And Performing

There is genuine resilience and there is performed resilience—a convincing display of coping designed to reassure others that you are managing. Performed resilience delays genuine recovery. Before you tell someone you are fine, pause and ask yourself if you actually are.

“Don’t perform resilience to make others comfortable—real strength begins the moment you admit you’re not fine.”

A Caution About Moving Too Quickly

The instinct to find the lesson, the silver lining, the growth—too soon after a setback—can be a way of bypassing the setback rather than building through it. There is no virtue in recovering faster than is honest.

A Question Worth Returning To

Think of the hardest thing you have already survived. You did not know, in the middle of it, that you would come through. But you did. What carried you? Whatever that was—that is your resilience. It already exists. The work is to recognize it, name it, and deliberately draw on it again.

Element two

ADAPTABILITY

Navigating The Rapids Of Change

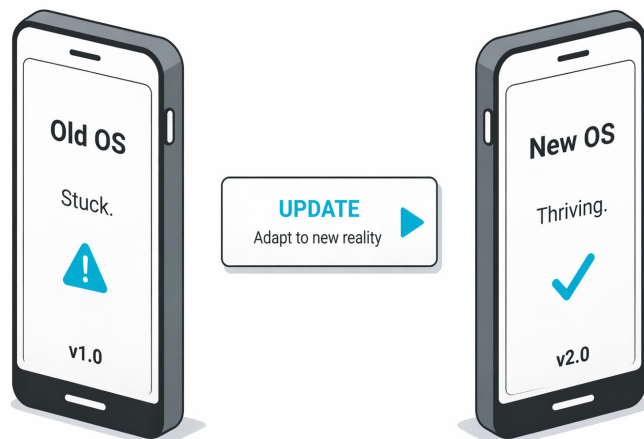
“Transforming Setbacks Into Action”

After Hikmat died, I did not know what to do with my days. I had been a management consultant—built firms, advised governments, travelled the world. And then that life was interrupted by a reality so large it made most of what I had been doing feel insufficient. Setbacks rearrange your priorities with a thoroughness that no productivity system could achieve. The question was whether I would adapt—actively, deliberately, with intention—or simply endure.

I chose to adapt. And the form that adaptation took surprised me: road safety. The very surface my son had been taken from. I turned to face the thing that had hurt me most and asked: how do I make this better?

“Adaptability is the decision to dance with change rather than be swept away by it.”

Think of your mind as a smartphone. Every few months, the operating system needs an update—not because the old version was broken, but because the world it operates in has changed. Adaptability is the willingness to update. The strategies that served you in one chapter may not serve you in the next.



How To Adapt: Five Principles

- **Allow your identity to shift:** Loss does not just take a person or a situation from you—it takes a version of yourself. The shape of who you were before may no longer fit. This is not a failure. It is an invitation to discover who you are capable of becoming.
- **Follow what still stirs something in you:** In the fog of setbacks, energy is scarce. Do not spend it on what you think you should want. Notice the small things that still produce a flicker of interest or purpose—however surprising, however different from before. That flicker is your compass.
- **Let the first attempt be imperfect:** The identity and direction you build after loss will not be correct on the first try. That is not failure—that is how rebuilding works. The willingness to try at all is what matters.
- **Be patient with your own timeline:** Other people will adapt to your loss before you do. The world will move on at a pace that can feel cruel. Your adaptation will take as long as it takes. There is no schedule.
- **Keep one door open that was not open before:** Setbacks have a way of closing things. Deliberately keep one new door ajar: a conversation you would not have had before, a direction you would not have considered, a person you would not have known.

A Story Of Adaptability: Graça Machel

On the night of 19 October 1986, the aircraft carrying Samora Machel—the founder of modern Mozambique and Graça’s husband of eleven years—crashed near the South African border.

He and thirty-four others were killed. Graça was forty-one years old, with two young children, and a life built entirely alongside the man who was now gone. The world expected her to step back.

“Adaptability is not about becoming someone else. It is about finding the best possible way to be yourself.”

She bounced forward. In the years that followed, she founded the Foundation for Community Development in Mozambique, accepted a United Nations appointment to investigate the impact of armed conflict on children, and spent two years traveling through conflict zones gathering testimony. Her 1996 report to the UN General Assembly directly created the mandate for a Special Representative for Children and Armed Conflict—a protection that still operates today.

BOUNCING FORWARD

She did not adapt by becoming someone new. She adapted by becoming more fully herself—taking every skill, every hard-earned authority, every lesson setbacks had forced on her, and directing it outward, forward.

Reflect On Adaptability

- When have you thrived in a situation where others struggled? What does that say about your ability to adapt?
- Have you ever changed a strongly held belief because of a new experience? What changed your mind?
- If life suddenly shifted you to a completely different career or lifestyle, how would you use your existing skills?

Cultivate A Mindset Of Continuous Learning

Always be ready to acquire new knowledge and skills. By maintaining curiosity and openness, you prepare yourself to adapt swiftly and effectively to whatever comes.

Embrace Trial And Error

Adaptability involves a degree of trial and error. Each attempt — whether successful or not — is a learning opportunity that builds resilience and enhances your ability to navigate future changes.

“She did not adapt by becoming someone new. She adapted by becoming more fully herself”

Begin With What Still Fits

You do not have to rebuild everything at once. Ask: what from my previous life still fits who I am now? Start there. Let the rest reveal itself over time.

Element three OPTIMISM

Lighting The Path Through The Darkness

Here is something the optimism literature rarely admits: being optimistic is hard. Pessimism is effortless. Your brain is designed for it. The human nervous system evolved to detect threat, anticipate danger, and catalog everything that could go wrong. This was useful when the threats were lions and famines. It is less useful when the threat is a difficult conversation, a failed project, or an empty afternoon the mind fills with its darkest imaginings. Optimism requires active effort. It is a practice, not a personality type. In the months after Hikmat's death, there were days when optimism felt not just difficult but obscene—a betrayal of grief, a refusal to honor what had been lost. I sat with those days. But I also held, even in those days, a small and stubborn conviction: that something good would emerge from this.

Optimism is not pretending the forest is a meadow. It is choosing to believe there is a way through.

“Harvesting Hope From Heartache.”

Optimism: Two Pairs Of Glasses



Flight Glasses

-  Obstacles
-  Too Risky
-  Give Up



Fight Glasses

-  Opportunities
-  Worth It
-  Keep Going

How To Practice Optimism Daily

- **Do not force it — observe it instead:** You cannot command yourself to feel optimistic in the middle of a setback. But you can notice: what, today, did not break me? What small thing still worked? What moment, even briefly, carried some quality of light? Observation is the first practice. Forced positivity is a performance. This is different.
- **Distinguish between the darkness of this moment and the story of your life:** Setbacks have a way of feeling permanent — as though the weight you are carrying now is the weight you will always carry. Practice separating the two: this is how I feel today is not the same sentence as this is who I am or this is how it will always be.
- **Challenge negative thoughts:** When a dark thought crosses your mind, hold it up to the light. Test it. Ask: is this actually true? Then swap it for something more accurate and more hopeful.
- **Find one person who has carried what you are carrying and come through:** Not to compare suffering. Not to be told it gets better. But to see, in a real human face, that the road through exists. That person's continued presence in the world is an act of optimism whether they know it or not.
- **Commit to positive action:** Optimism is not passive. Engage in activities that reinforce a forward-looking outlook: set goals, volunteer, build something that creates positive change.

A Story of Optimism: Immaculée Ilibagiza

In April 1994, Immaculée Ilibagiza was a twenty-two-year-old student home in Rwanda for Easter. Within days, the genocide began. Her mother, her father, two of her brothers—murdered. She survived by hiding in a pastor's bathroom, three feet by four feet, with seven other women, for ninety-one days.

She emerged weighing sixty-five pounds. During those ninety-one days, she did not surrender her mind to the darkness outside. She prayed. She taught herself English from a Bible she had brought into that room.

“You will always be tempted to give in to rage and obsession. But if you succumb to the temptation, the setbacks would have taken everything from you.”

She made a decision—not once, but every single day—to believe that something worth living for still existed on the other side.

Reflect On Optimism

- When everything seems to be going against you, how do you find a silver lining to keep moving forward?
- If you knew you couldn't fail, what would you attempt? Does knowing you might fail hold you back from trying?
- Can you recall a moment when your positive attitude dramatically influenced the outcome of a seemingly negative situation?

Embrace The “Fight” Perspective

Choose to view challenges through the Fight glasses — seeing each difficulty as an opportunity to grow stronger. This turns potential setbacks into stepping stones for personal development.

“Optimism is not a passive state but an active pursuit.”

Cultivate Gratitude In Daily Life

Make it a habit to recognize and appreciate the good in your life, no matter how small. This practice shifts your focus from what's going wrong to what's going right — reinforcing an optimistic mindset.

Commit To Continuous Positive Action

Optimism is not a passive state but an active pursuit. Engage in actions that reinforce your optimistic outlook and create positive change in your community.

Element Four

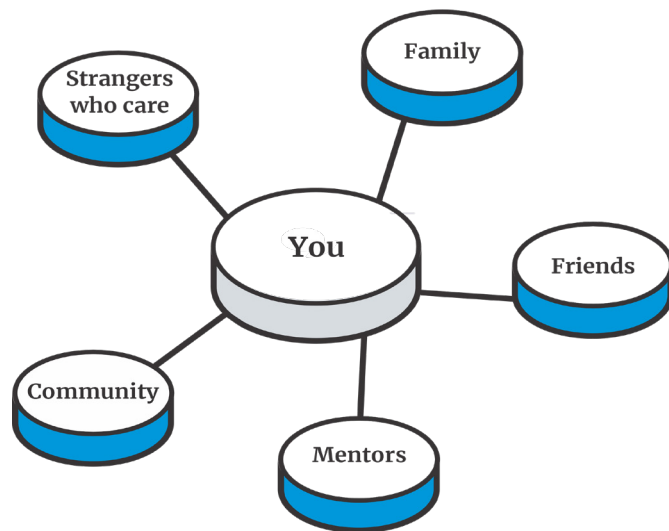
SUPPORT

Weaving A Net Of Collective Strength

“United by Hikmat’s Memory in a Network of Compassion”

I have tried to imagine what those days would have been like without the people who showed up. My family, constant. Friends who came from another country—left their jobs, their routines, their ordinary lives—to sit with me for a week. Strangers who arrived at the door because they felt, across the distance of not knowing me, that they should. I tried to imagine facing it alone. I could not. The thought felt like the ceiling coming down.

“No one crosses any significant forest alone. Every great transformation was made possible by someone who stood beside the traveler when they could not stand by themselves.”



Support as a Two-Way Architecture

Support flows in both directions, or it does not flow at all. The network that sustained me through Hikmat's death was not built after his death. It was built over decades—through the Al-Jude Foundation, through volunteer work, through the simple daily practice of showing up for people when they needed something. Research in psychology confirms what lived experience already knows: strong social ties boost immune function, reduce stress, and improve overall mental health. Support can be physical, emotional, or practical. A diverse network ensures you receive all three.

“Support flows in both directions, or it does not flow at all.”

How to Build Your Support Web

- **Say what you actually need:** The people around you want to help but often do not know how. Sharing your thoughts shows trust and helps others understand you better. Let them in.
- **Build your support before the next storm:** The network that can hold you in your worst moments is built in the ordinary ones. The time to invest in relationships is not when crisis arrives—it is in every quiet day before it.
- **Accept that different people carry different things:** One person will make you laugh. Another will sit in silence without needing to fill it. Another will help with the practical weight. Do not expect any single person to carry everything. A support web works because its strength is distributed.
- **Notice who stays:** Not everyone will. Some people will disappear when you need them most. Notice, instead, the ones who remain—who call, who arrive, who stay without being asked. These are your people. Hold them close and tell them so.
- **Let people show up imperfectly:** Those around you will say the wrong thing. They will offer comfort that misses. Try to receive the intention rather than judging the execution. People who love you are also navigating something they do not know how to handle.

A Story of Support: Abdul Sattar Edhi

Abdul Sattar Edhi began with a single room in Karachi in the 1950s. He had almost nothing. But he had one conviction: “No religion is higher than humanity.”

Over the following decades, he built an infrastructure of care—ambulances, orphanages, shelters—that touched millions of lives. His wife Bilquis’s steady, unglamorous daily support gave him the platform from which everything was built.

“The support web is built in the quiet seasons. It holds you in the storms.”

Reflect On Support

- Think of a time when someone’s support changed your life’s trajectory. What would have happened without it?
- Who is your unsung hero — the person who always lifts you up? What have they sacrificed that no one else knows?
- If you had to thank someone for their invisible support during a tough time, who would it be, and what would you say?

Invest In Emotional Reserves

Every small gesture of kindness builds a reserve. This emotional wealth ensures you have ample support to draw on when you face life’s challenges.

Recognize Support As A Two-Way Street

True support involves both giving and receiving. Identify one person in your life who showed up for you during a difficult time—and whom you have not properly thanked. Send them a message this week. Not a long one. Simply: I want you to know that what you did mattered.

A Caution About Isolation In Setbacks

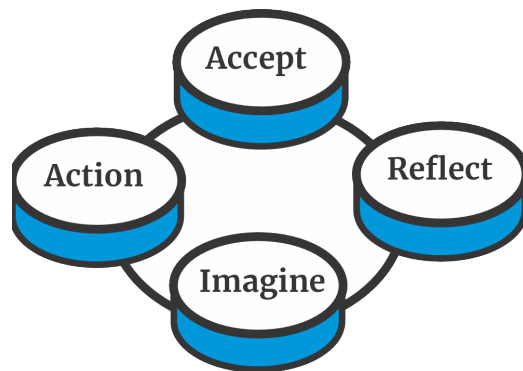
Setbacks create a powerful pull toward isolation—the feeling that your pain is too heavy to ask others to bear. This feeling is almost always wrong, and almost always harmful. The people around you do not need to understand your setbacks perfectly to offer something useful. Presence alone is a form of support. Do not let the pursuit of perfect understanding stop you from accepting imperfect, genuine human company.

Chapter 3 THE 4-STEP MODEL

BOUNCING FORWARD

Surviving tough times isn't about going back to how things were before. It's a chance to reach a place that's stronger, reinforced, and more resilient. The 4-Step Model guides you through this time of significant change—starting with Acceptance and ending with Action. These steps are not a formula. Life does not move in straight lines, and setbacks least of all. But they are stepping stones—a way of putting one foot in front of the other with intention, rather than simply enduring.

“Surviving tough times isn’t about going back to how things were before.”



Step One **ACCEPT** Embracing The Inevitable

STEP ONE: ACCEPT

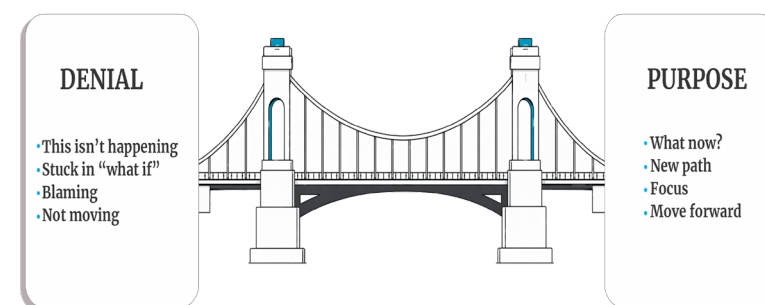
People deal with setbacks differently. For some, they do not enter the room of their departed loved one. The room remains exactly as it was left—their things in their places, the particular arrangement of their world, undisturbed. I am sometimes asked whether this means the loss has not been accepted. Whether the closed door is evidence of denial, of setbacks unprocessed, of a wound still open. It is the opposite. The room is not a shrine to denial. It is a monument to acceptance. It says: this chapter of our story happened. It was real. It mattered.

I am not going to rearrange the furniture of my loved one's memory as though it never existed. Acceptance means acknowledging the full truth: Hikmat was here. He was taken before his time. That fact will never change. The question I must answer every morning is not "how do I go back?" but "who am I, carrying this, going forward?"

"Acceptance is not surrender. It is the bridge between who you were before the loss and who you are still capable of becoming."

The Room You Have Not Entered

Acceptance: The Bridge Forward



The Danger of the What-Ifs

In the hours after Hikmat was taken to hospital, my mind ran the alternative timelines. What if we had left the house differently that night? What if he had taken another road? These questions are natural. They are also a trap. The sequence of events is what it was. It cannot be revised. Every moment spent in the labyrinth of “what if” is a moment not spent in the only time available: now. There are two questions a person can ask after a loss. The first is: why did this happen? It has no answer. The second is: who am I, carrying this, going forward? It demands one. The shift between these two questions is where acceptance begins to become something useful.

“Every moment spent in the labyrinth of ‘what if’ is a moment not spent in the only time available: now.”

How To Accept

- **Acknowledge your feelings:** Recognize and express your emotions without judgment. Allow yourself to feel grief, anger, or confusion — these are natural responses to loss.
- **Seek understanding:** Try to understand the situation fully. Whether by gathering facts or seeking spiritual clarity, comprehension can facilitate acceptance.
- **Create rituals of closure:** Engage in personal or communal rituals that mark the end of one chapter and the beginning of another.
- **Preserve memories positively:** Keep memories alive in ways that honor the departed — a scholarship fund, a community project, a dedicated space.
- **Redirect your energy:** Focus on what can be changed. Engage in activities that reinforce a sense of control and forward purpose.

A Story of Acceptance: Nelson Mandela

On February 11, 1990, Nelson Mandela walked out of Victor Verster Prison after twenty-seven years of incarceration. Reporters expected a man consumed by righteous fury. Instead, they found a man at peace—a man who had accepted not merely his own suffering but the necessity of transforming it into something that could serve a future larger than himself. Twenty-seven years. And he walked out free—because he had already done the harder work inside.

Reflect On Acceptance

- How has accepting a challenging reality changed your approach to life and relationships?
- What would you say to someone who is struggling to accept a significant change or loss?
- What rituals or activities might help you in accepting changes in your life?

“As I walked out the door toward freedom, I knew if I didn’t leave my bitterness and hatred behind, I’d still be in prison.”

Acceptance Enables Peace

Accepting the reality of loss or change is the first step toward finding inner peace. Try this: once each day, say to yourself—silently or aloud—one thing that is true about your loss, without immediately following it with a qualification or a comfort. This happened. It was real. It is part of my life now. The act of naming it, without softening it, is the practice.

Let Go Of The What-Ifs

Dwelling on unanswerable questions keeps you anchored in the past. What is the specific thing about your loss that is hardest to accept—not the loss itself, but one particular aspect of it? The what-if you cannot release, the unfairness that still burns, the future that was taken with it? Naming that specific thing is usually where the real work of acceptance begins.

A Caution About Confusing Acceptance with Approval

Accepting a loss does not mean agreeing that it should have happened, or that it was fair, or that you are at peace with it. It means acknowledging that it did happen, and that the only territory available to you is the one that begins from here. You can accept a reality while still finding it unjust. That tension is not a contradiction—it is the truth of most significant losses.

Step Two

REFLECT

Uncovering Insight From Setbacks

The Question That Changed Everything

About six months after Hikmat's death, I sat down with a newspaper and a piece of paper, and I began to count. The numbers shook me in a way that grief, paradoxically, had not. Grief had made me numb. These numbers made me furious. The annual traffic fatalities on Jordan's roads, laid alongside the casualty figures from the conflict in neighboring Palestine, made our highways look like a war zone.

We were killing our own children—with cars, inattention, and the absence of any coherent national strategy. And no one was talking about it. That afternoon—with a newspaper and a piece of paper—was the moment Hikmat's death became Hikmat's legacy.

“Reflection transforms pain into purpose — turning what happened to us into what we do with it.”

What Reflection Actually Is

Not journaling in a pleasant sense. Not a quiet cup of tea with your thoughts. Reflection is the disciplined, sometimes uncomfortable practice of letting experience become wisdom—of sitting with what has happened until it tells you something true and useful about where you need to go next. The question that does this work is not: why did this happen? It is: what does this ask of me going forward? That single shift turns reflection from a backward glance into a direction.

How to Reflect

- **Set aside time for introspection:** There is no correct moment to begin. But when you do, the only reflection worth doing is the honest kind. Ask: what is actually true here? Not: what do I wish were true?
- **Sit with the question “what does this ask of me?”:** Not why did this happen. Not what did I do to deserve this. But: what does this loss ask of me going forward? This is the question that turns reflection from a backward glance into a direction. It is also the hardest question, which is why it is worth returning to.

- **Write it down, even badly:** The act of putting setbacks into words—however clumsy, however private, however incomplete—externalises the weight. It gives the formless a form. You do not need to write well. You need to write honestly.
- **Discuss with trusted others:** Sharing your thoughts with a trusted friend or mentor can provide new perspectives and enhance your understanding.
- **Use creative outlets:** Sometimes engaging in creative activities — painting, writing, music can facilitate deeper reflection and emotional expression.

A Story of Reflection: Gandhi's Day of Silence

Once a week, Mahatma Gandhi did not speak. He observed a weekly day of silence as a practice of self-examination—a deliberate pause in the machinery of action and communication. A space to assess what he had done, recalibrate his thinking, and ensure that his next week's actions would be more aligned with his values.

In the middle of leading one of the most consequential political movements in modern history, he considered one day in seven too valuable a price not to pay for clarity. You do not need a full day of silence. Start with twenty minutes on a Sunday evening. Sit with your week. What happened? What did I learn? What do I want to do differently?

“The most successful people I have met share one practice: they pause. Regularly and deliberately, they think about what they are doing and why.”

BOUNCING FORWARD

Reflect On Reflection

- What moments in your life have led to significant personal revelations?
- Can you think of a time when reflection changed your perspective or behavior?
- How can you incorporate regular reflection into your daily or weekly routine?

“You don’t need a system or an hour—just one honest question, answered honestly. Reflection moves you forward; rumination keeps you circling the same wound.”

The Practice: One Question, Not Many

If formal reflection feels too large to begin, reduce it to a single question at the end of one day this week: What did I feel today that I did not say out loud? Write the answer down, or simply sit with it for five minutes. You do not need a journal, a system, or a dedicated hour. You need one honest question, answered honestly. That is the beginning.

A Caution About Reflection That Circles Rather Than Moves

There is a difference between reflection and rumination. Reflection asks: what is this experience teaching me? and looks for an answer that can inform what comes next. Rumination asks the same questions repeatedly with no expectation of an answer—it circles the wound without treating it. If you find yourself returning to the same thoughts, the same what-ifs, without arriving anywhere new, it may be time to bring a trusted person into the conversation.

Build A Foundation For Growth

Reflection is the groundwork for personal growth — setting the stage for future improvements and innovations in one’s life.

Step Three

IMAGINE

Seeing the Path Forward

STEP THREE: IMAGINE

At some point in crossing a difficult season, you look up. You have been so focused on the immediate that you have not lifted your eyes to the horizon. And when you do—when you see through a gap in the canopy a distant peak catching the morning light—something changes. Not the difficulty. The difficulty is exactly as dense as before. What changes is your relationship to it. You are no longer simply moving. You are moving toward something specific. After my months of reflection, I had understood the problem: Jordan's roads were killing people at an unacceptable rate, and there was no national strategy to address it.

But analysis is not a goal. A goal has a name. A goal has a deadline. My goal became: build Jordan's first national traffic safety strategy, and implement the specific, measurable changes it demands.

“Bouncing Forward requires clear goals — specific, named destinations that organize every step that follows.”

The Mountain Through the Trees



From Vision to Goal: The SMART Bridge

Once you have imagined the destination, the next move is to give it shape — to translate vision into something concrete enough to act on. SMART goals—Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound—are a useful framework. Use them. But add something SMART alone does not capture: purpose. The goals that truly outlast difficulty are connected to what you care about most. When you set your goals, build the SMART framework. But before you do, ask yourself: whose face is attached to this goal? Who am I building this for, beyond myself? That question will give your goals a power no framework alone can provide.

“SMART goals give you structure—but purpose gives you strength. When a goal is tied to someone or something that matters, it stops being a task and becomes a reason to keep going.”

How to Envision What Comes Next

- **Start with purpose before you start with plans:** Before you name any specific goal, ask the deeper question: what is this for? The goals that sustain people through difficulty are the ones connected to something or someone that matters profoundly. Whose face is attached to this goal? That question is where to begin.
- **Let the vision be small enough to start today:** After loss, the horizon can feel impossibly far. A goal that takes five years to reach is of little use to someone struggling to get through the week. Name something you can begin today—not the destination, but the direction. One phone call. One conversation. One step.
- **Give the setback a name and a direction:** Uniform setbacks have nowhere to go. The moment you attach it to a specific goal—a foundation, a project, a commitment—it begins to transform from weight into fuel. This is not about rushing past the setback. It is about giving it a purpose that honours what was lost.
- **Be willing to revise:** The goal you set from the middle of grief will not be the same goal you would have set before it, and it may not be the same goal you will have in a year. Let your goals be living things. As you change, let them change with you.
- **Measure by meaning, not only by achievement:** Ask also: does this still feel connected to what matters most to me? For goals born from setbacks, the most important measure is whether the work continues to honour the reason you began.

A Story of Imagination: Chido Govera

When Chido Govera was seven years old, her mother died of AIDS in a village near Mutare, Zimbabwe. She was left as the sole provider for her five-year-old brother and her nearly blind grandmother. At eight, she endured abuse at the hands of family members. At ten, she was offered a way out—marriage to a man thirty years her senior. She refused. Because at eight years old, in the middle of everything that was happening to her, she had made herself a promise: when I am older, I will make sure no other orphan has to live the way I am living. That was her goal. Unwritten. But specific, and entirely her own.

“Growing Mushrooms in waste taught me that I could convert my life from what it is today into something much better.”

At eleven, she was selected for a mushroom-farming training programme, learning to grow food from agricultural waste. By sixteen she was earning enough to send her brother to school. She went on to found The Future of Hope Foundation, training over two thousand people across Zimbabwe, Tanzania, the Congo, India, and Colombia. She named her goal at eight years old, in grief, with nothing. Everything else followed from that. She imagined her future at eight years old, in setbacks, with nothing. Everything else followed from that. A goal does not eliminate hardship. It gives hardship a direction.

Reflect on Imagination

- What is one goal you have set for yourself that aligns closely with your personal values?
- How do you break down your larger goals into manageable steps?
- Can you recall a time when adjusting your goals led to better outcomes?

BOUNCING FORWARD

Name One Thing By Friday

Before the end of this week, write down one specific thing you want to be different in your life in six months' time. Not a resolution. Not a system. One sentence describing something concrete that does not yet exist.

It does not need to be large. It does not need to be certain. It only needs to be honest—something you actually want, for a reason that actually matters to you. This is where a goal begins.

“It only needs to be honest—something you actually want, for a reason that actually matters to you.”

The Power Of Incremental Steps

Achieving large goals becomes more feasible when broken down into smaller, actionable steps. Especially when dealing with loss, the smaller the steps, the better. Progress compounds.

Clarify Purpose

Well-defined goals help clarify our purpose, giving a clear direction and strong motivation. The more specific the goal, the more powerful the pull toward it.

Step Four

TAKE ACTION

Catalyzing Change Through Initiative

STEP FOUR: ACTION

When I looked at Jordan's roads and said "there is no national traffic safety strategy, and there needs to be one," the gap between that diagnosis and its solution looked enormous. I was not a government minister. I had no official mandate. I had grief, some consulting experience, and a conviction that became, over time, impossible to ignore. So I started where I could. I studied traffic safety strategies from eighteen countries. I started conversations. I used every professional relationship I had built over two decades. I found allies in government, in civil society, in the private sector. I built a draft strategy. I did not wait for permission.

The result: 1,800 hazardous locations identified and addressed. 260 schools marked and made safer. Over 1,200 playgrounds built. A national strategy now guiding Jordan's approach to road safety. That is how things get built—not in a single heroic moment, but in thousands of ordinary moments of decided, unglamorous effort.

"Turning vision into reality demands action. Not perfect action. Not fearless action. Just the next step, taken."

Mobilizing Safety with Hikmat's Vision



Five Principles for Action

- **Start before you are ready:** You will never feel completely ready. The conditions will never be right. Setbacks have a way of making everything feel premature. Begin anyway. The doing creates the readiness that waiting never will. The first step does not need to be large. It only needs to be real.
- **Build your team before you need them:** The collaborations that made our road safety work possible began years earlier, through relationships built in good faith. Your team is built in the quiet seasons, not the urgent ones. Build broadly and generously.
- **Celebrate the milestones no one else can see:** The first morning you woke and felt, briefly, something other than grief. The day you said the name of your loss in a room full of people and kept your voice steady. These internal victories are not visible to anyone else. Mark them anyway. They are the foundation of everything that follows.
- **Do not wait for permission:** No one will appoint you to rebuild your life. No authority will sanction your decision to make something purposeful from what you have lost. The mandate comes from within. Act from that conviction. That is permission enough.
- **When the plan breaks, stay committed to the purpose:** The specific path forward will change. Plans made during setbacks are made with incomplete information, and life will rearrange them. What must not change is the underlying reason—the person you are honouring, the commitment you made when you decided that the loss would become a legacy. Hold the purpose tightly. Hold the plan loosely.

“Hate is a heavy burden to carry. It destroys the one who carries it before it destroys the one it is aimed at.”

A Story of Action: Dr. Izzeldin Abuelaish

In January 2009, four months after his wife died of leukaemia, Dr. Izzeldin Abuelaish was on the phone to an Israeli television station—describing, as he did regularly, the conditions inside Gaza—when two tank shells struck his home. Three of his daughters were killed. His niece too. His screams were broadcast live. The world heard a man shattered.

What came next was his choice. He did not seek revenge. He accepted a fellowship at the University of Toronto, gathered his five surviving children, and began to build. He founded the Daughters for Life Foundation, offering scholarships and fellowships to girls and women across the Middle East—Palestinian and Israeli, Muslim, Christian, and Jewish alike. He wrote his story in a book, *I Shall Not Hate*, translated into twenty-three languages. He has been nominated five times for the Nobel Peace Prize. None of it erased what happened at a quarter to five on 16 January 2009. None of it was meant to. He named his foundation for his daughters because the work was theirs. The action was his. That is how it works — setbacks provide the reason; discipline provides everything else.

Reflect On Action

- What small, actionable step can you take today to move closer to your goal? How will you measure its impact?
- Can you identify a past situation where collaboration significantly enhanced the success of your efforts?
- How do you maintain your motivation and commitment when your actions do not yield immediate results?

“When the distance feels impossible, do the next smallest thing—because progress cannot follow nothing.”

Do The Next Smallest Thing

When the full distance feels impossible, stop looking at it. Ask instead: what is the smallest possible action I can take in the next hour? Not tomorrow. This hour. Then take it. The purpose of the smallest possible action is not to make significant progress—it is to break the paralysis, to prove to yourself that movement is still available to you. Progress follows. But it cannot follow nothing.

Don’t Mistake Busyness For Action

Loss can produce a particular kind of frantic activity—filling every hour, committing to every project, staying in constant motion—that looks like action but is actually avoidance. True action is purposeful: connected to the goal, which is connected to the reflection, which is connected to the loss. Every so often, stop and ask: what is this for?

BOUNCING FORWARD

Celebrate Each Milestone

Recognizing and celebrating each step of progress builds momentum and sustains motivation throughout the entire journey. Each step forward is the foundation for the next, and is worth taking the time to acknowledge.

Chapter 4

TAKING STOCK

An Honest Inventory & Personal Action Plan

Before you answer a single question, I want to tell you something about myself. I am not, by nature, a person who sits still easily. My default is action. Movement. The next project, the next journey, the next problem to solve. In the months after Hikmat's death, this was both my greatest strength and my most persistent obstacle — because grief requires a kind of stillness that everything in my character resisted. If you had asked me in February 2008 where my lights were burning, I would have told you: Resilience, strong. Optimism, intact. Adaptability, reliable. Support, sufficient. Every one of those answers would have been wrong.

Not because I was lying to you. Because I was lying to myself — scoring myself against the man I had been before January 2008, not the man I actually was in the middle of my loss. I was performing answers rather than living them.

“The map that lies about the terrain is not a kindness to the traveller. It is a danger.”

And the gap between the performance and the reality was exactly where my healing was most needed. That is why this inventory exists. Not to test you. Not to produce a verdict. But to give you the most useful thing a traveller in unfamiliar terrain can have: an honest map of where you actually are.

There is a particular way that setbacks distort self-knowledge. In the weeks after Hikmat died, I was convinced I understood myself. I had built companies, advised governments, navigated complexity for decades. I was not someone who lacked self-awareness. And yet I barely knew myself at all during that time — because grief had rearranged everything, and I had not yet looked clearly at the new arrangement. That is what we are about to do together.

How to Use the Inventory

This is not a quiz with right or wrong answers. It is an honest conversation between you and yourself — the kind that setbacks often interrupt, and the kind that healing eventually requires. For each of the eight dimensions of the Bouncing Forward framework, you will find three things.

First, a description — an honest portrait of what that dimension looks, feels, and sounds like across a range of human experience, from barely flickering to burning bright. Read it slowly. Not to find where you should be. To find where you actually are.

Second, a simple marking — a five-point scale from which you choose one honest position. There are no wrong marks. There is only the mark that is true.

Third, three reflection questions — open invitations rather than examinations. You do not need to answer all of them in full. A single honest sentence is worth more than a performed paragraph. Write in the margins if you want. Let the questions sit if they are not yet ready to be answered.

At the end, the inventory leads you into a Personal Action Plan — a map of the specific steps you are committing to, based on where you honestly found yourself. One instruction above all others: answer as you are right now. Not who you were before the loss. Not who you intend to become. Here. Now. In the particular chapter of life you are currently living. This is the only place the journey forward can begin.

Part One: Your Compass

The 4-Element Framework

Element 1: Resilience

How brightly is this light burning?

Resilience is not toughness. It is not the refusal to feel pain, or the ability to recover faster than the setbacks demand. It is closer to what the bamboo tree knows without knowing it: that bending in a storm is not the same as breaking.

When resilience is burning bright, you find yourself able to carry difficulty without being defined by it. Hard days are hard, but they pass. You have a sense — even faint, even imperfect — that you have survived difficult things before, and that this evidence means something. You can be brought low without being brought down permanently.

When resilience is flickering, the days feel heavier and less recoverable. Difficulty feels like a verdict rather than a weather system. The evidence of past survival — and it exists, because you are here, reading these words — is hard to access or trust. This is not a character failure. This is what setbacks do to a person who is carrying more than they were built to carry alone.

Most people reading this book will find their resilience somewhere in the middle. That is honest, and it is human. The inventory is simply asking you to look.

How brightly is this light burning?

☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
BARELY FLICKERING	FAINT	PARTIAL	STEADY	BRIGHT

Circle the word that is honest.

Reflect

- Think of the hardest thing you have already survived. You did not know, in the middle of it, that you would come through. But you did. What carried you? Whatever that was — that is your resilience. It already exists. Can you name it?
- Is there a difference between the resilience you are performing — the version you show the world — and the resilience you are actually feeling? What lives in that gap?
- What would change if you allowed yourself to need more support than you are currently admitting you need?

Element 2: Adaptability

How brightly is this light burning?

Adaptability is the willingness to become someone you had not planned to be, in a world you had not planned to inhabit. It asks more of us than almost any other quality — because it asks us to release the identity and the future we had been building, and find a new shape for our existence.

When adaptability is burning bright, you find yourself able to follow where the new reality leads — not without difficulty, not without grief for what was, but with a kind of openness to becoming. You can update your picture of yourself and your future in response to what has changed, rather than pressing the old picture against a world that no longer fits it.

When adaptability is flickering, the same strategies, the same routines, the same self-conception feel increasingly like armour you are wearing rather than a life you are living. You may find yourself trying to rebuild exactly what was, rather than discovering what might be. This is not failure. It is loyalty — to a life and a person and a future that deserved to continue. Setbacks often looks like resistance to change because it is grief, not stubbornness.

Where is your adaptability light burning right now?

☐ BARELY FLICKERING	☐ FAINT	☐ PARTIAL	☐ STEADY	☐ BRIGHT
---	--------------------------------	----------------------------------	---------------------------------	---------------------------------

Circle the word that is honest.

Reflect

- Since your loss, what has already shifted in you — however small? You may not have chosen the change, but it has happened. Can you name it honestly, without judging it as progress or its absence?
- Is there something in your life right now that you are trying to rebuild into its old shape, when the new shape may need to be different? What are you afraid would be lost if you let the new shape be different?
- What is one thing that has surprised you about who you are becoming — something you would not have predicted before this?

Element 3: Optimism
How brightly is this light burning?

The optimism this book is describing is not the cheerful variety — the insistence that everything happens for a reason, or the performance of positivity in the face of genuine darkness. That kind of optimism is not a light. It is a curtain.

What this book means by optimism is closer to a decision: the daily, renewable choice to believe that forward is still possible. It can coexist with setbacks. It can be present alongside deep sadness, genuine uncertainty, and the knowledge that some things will never be restored. It asks only this: that you do not give the darkness the final word.

When optimism is burning bright, it does not mean your days are easy. It means that somewhere beneath the difficulty, you hold the possibility that this is not all there is — that the road still continues, and that the person you are becoming through this is someone worth becoming.

When optimism is barely flickering, the future can feel foreclosed — not as a thought you have chosen, but as a fact that setbacks have imposed. This is one of the most honest responses to genuine loss, and it is important not to be ashamed of it. The work here is not to feel optimistic. It is simply not to close the door on it.

Where is your optimism light burning right now?

☐ BARELY FLICKERING	☐ FAINT	☐ PARTIAL	☐ STEADY	☐ BRIGHT
---	--------------------------------	----------------------------------	---------------------------------	---------------------------------

Circle the word that is honest.

Reflect

- When you imagine your life twelve months from now, what do you see? Not what you fear you will see — what you actually see, or hope to see. Can you hold that image, however faint, without dismissing it?
- Is there a difference between the optimism you have — the quiet belief in forward — and the optimism you feel? If so, which one do you want to trust?
- Who in your life carries genuine optimism — not the performed kind, but the earned kind that has survived difficulty? What do you notice about how they hold it?

Element 4: Support

How brightly is this light burning?

Support, in the context of this book, is not simply the presence of people who love you. It is your willingness and ability to let them in — to allow what you are carrying to be shared, and to allow yourself to be sustained by something other than your own resources.

Many of the most capable, self-sufficient people I have known struggle most with this one. They are the people who give support easily and receive it with difficulty — who have built their identity on being the one who holds things together, and who find it threatening, even shameful, to need holding themselves.

When support is burning bright, the exchange of care flows naturally in both directions. You can ask for what you need. You can be specific about the form help should take. You can allow yourself to be known in the parts of yourself that are still struggling. You carry your loss as a shared weight rather than a private one.

When support is flickering, you may be near people who love you and still feel profoundly alone — because the connection is present but the vulnerability required to use it is not. Loss has a way of making us feel that our pain is too much to ask others to bear. And so we carry it alone at precisely the moment when connection matters most.

How brightly is your support light burning?

☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
BARELY FLICKERING	FAINT	PARTIAL	STEADY	BRIGHT

Circle the word that is honest.

Reflect

- Who is the person in your life who could hold the weight of what you are actually carrying — not the version you perform, but the real version? Have you let them hold it?
- What makes it difficult to ask for help? Is it a fear of being a burden? A belief that you should be managing better? Something else? Try to name it specifically.
- Is there a way that giving support to others has become, for you, a substitute for receiving it? If so, what might it look like to let the balance shift?

Part Two: Your Path

The 4-Model

Step 1: Acceptance

How accessible is this step right now?

Acceptance is the most misunderstood word in the vocabulary of setbacks.

It does not mean that what happened was acceptable. It does not mean you are glad it occurred, or that you have finished feeling the impact of the setback, or that the loss has stopped mattering. It means only that you are no longer spending your energy fighting the fact that it happened.

There is a kind of setback that stays locked in the space before acceptance — that returns, again and again, to the moment of loss and refuses to move past the question of why. This is not a failure of character. It is often a form of loyalty — an unwillingness to move forward that feels, at some level, like it would mean leaving the person or the moment behind. Understanding this, rather than judging it, is the first step.

When acceptance is accessible, you find yourself able to carry the reality of what happened without being consumed by the fight against it. This does not mean at peace. It means honest. The loss is real. It happened. And you are still here, still finding a way.

When acceptance feels distant, you may find yourself still in the question of why, still in the negotiation with a reality that will not change, still waking each day with a part of yourself that has not yet admitted what happened. If that is where you are, it is not a problem to solve. It is a stage of the journey.

Where are you with acceptance right now?

☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
NOT YET POSSIBLE	BEGINNING	PARTIAL	MOST DAYS	SETTLED

Circle the word that is honest.

Reflect

- What specifically is hardest for you to accept about your loss? Often the most resisted truth is the most important one to sit with. Try to name it as precisely as you can.
- Is there a way that staying in the fight against what happened feels like loyalty to what you lost? If so, is that a loyalty that is serving you — or holding you?
- What would it mean for you to carry this loss rather than fight it? Not to be done with it — simply to carry it. Can you feel the difference between those two things?

Step 2: Self-Reflection

How accessible is this step right now?

Self-reflection requires a kind of stillness that setbacks rarely make easy. The mind that is in pain often prefers motion — more activity, more noise, more doing — because the alternative is to sit with what hurts, and that is an act of extraordinary courage.

Reflection, as this book understands it, is not analysis for its own sake. It is not the endless examination of what went wrong, or the cataloguing of your own failures, or the search for someone to hold responsible. It is the practice of looking at your own life and your own inner state with honesty and without judgment — asking not just what happened, but what it is asking of you.

When reflection is accessible, you find yourself able to sit with your experience rather than run from it. You can look at your patterns, your responses, your setbacks, and your growth with something approaching clarity. You know yourself better today than you did before, and that knowledge — hard-won as it is — is beginning to feel like an asset.

When reflection is difficult, the idea of sitting still with your own thoughts may feel threatening rather than useful. You may be using activity, distraction, or the care of others as a way of staying away from something that needs to be met. That avoidance is understandable. But what we avoid, we cannot integrate.

Where are you with self-reflection right now?

☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
NOT YET POSSIBLE	BEGINNING	PARTIAL	MOST DAYS	SETTLED

Circle the word that is honest.

Reflect

- When you sit quietly and turn your attention inward, what do you meet? Is it grief? Numbness? Anxiety? Something unexpected? Try to name it without judging it.
- Is there something in your experience that you have been moving past rather than through — something that comes up and that you consistently redirect your attention away from? What is it?
- What have you learned about yourself since your loss that you would not have learned any other way? Even one thing, however small or unwelcome. Can you hold it?

Step 3: Imagining New Goals

How accessible is this step right now?

After a significant setback, the idea of setting goals can feel not just premature but almost offensive — as though the act of planning forward is a betrayal of what was lost, a sign that you have accepted the loss’s terms too easily, moved on when moving on is the last thing the moment deserves.

I want to name that feeling directly, because it is real and it is common, and because it can keep people from one of the most powerful steps in the entire journey.

Goals, in this context, are not a declaration that the setback is over. They are a declaration that it will not be the last word. A goal after loss does not need to be large, or ambitious, or connected to professional achievement. It can be small: a direction that gives the next day a

shape, a commitment that connects your pain to something beyond it. What matters is not the scale of the goal but the quality of its meaning — whether it carries the weight of what you have lost, and whether its achievement would honour that weight.

When goal-setting is accessible, you find yourself able to hold a horizon. Not an easy or certain future, but a direction — something you are building, someone you are becoming, a purpose that connects your loss to something larger than the loss itself.

When goal-setting feels distant, the future may feel foreclosed or irrelevant. This is a signal worth taking seriously — not as failure, but as information about where your healing currently stands.

Where are you with setting new goals right now?

☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
NOT YET POSSIBLE	BEGINNING	PARTIAL	MOST DAYS	SETTLED

Circle the word that is honest.

Reflect

- Is there something you are already building, even quietly, even without fully naming it as a goal? A direction you find yourself moving toward even on difficult days? Try to name it.
- What goal, if you achieved it, would feel most like an honouring of what you have been through — not a replacement for what was lost, but a use of it?
- Who is attached to the goal you are building? Goals that are connected to someone — to a love, a loss, a legacy — have a staying power that ambition alone cannot sustain. Whose face is in yours?

Step 4: Taking Action

How accessible is this step right now?

There is a difference between resting and being frozen. Both can look the same from the outside. Both can feel justified. But they are not the same thing.

Resting is what the body and the heart require after genuine loss. It is not weakness or avoidance — it is honest recovery, and it should be respected rather than rushed. There are seasons of hardship in which the most courageous thing you can do is simply to endure, to be still, to allow yourself to not yet be ready.

Frozen is different. Frozen is when rest has become a permanent shelter — when the stillness that was once recovery has become a way of avoiding the next step. It often announces itself through a particular thought: I will begin when I feel ready. But readiness, in the aftermath of loss, rarely arrives on its own. It is almost always something you have to take a step toward before you feel it.

When action is flowing, you find yourself moving — small steps or large, but moving. You have the capacity to begin, to adjust when the plan changes, and to return to the work when difficulty interrupts. You have learned that momentum is something you can create rather than wait for.

When action feels frozen, the first step is simply the question: what is the smallest possible movement I can make today? Not a plan. Not a commitment. A single small thing.

Where are you with taking action right now?

☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
NOT YET POSSIBLE	BEGINNING	PARTIAL	MOST DAYS	SETTLED

Circle the word that is honest.

Reflect

- What would the smallest possible first step look like — something that takes ten minutes or less, that would represent any movement at all? Not a plan. A single step. Name it.
- Under what conditions does your momentum most often falter? Is it when you encounter resistance from others? When the goal feels too far away? When grief surges unexpectedly? Knowing where you tend to stop is the first step toward not stopping there.
- What would it mean to act before you feel ready? Not recklessly — but with the knowledge that readiness sometimes follows the first step rather than preceding it?

Your Personal Plan

From honest inventory to honest commitment

The inventory you just completed is a snapshot — a map of the terrain as it currently stands, drawn by the most honest cartographer available: you. Now it is time to use that map. Look back at your eight markings. Notice which lights are burning steadily and which are flickering. Notice which steps feel accessible and which feel distant. This is not a measure of your character. It is a measure of where your healing currently stands, and it is the only honest starting point for the work that follows. Use the space below. Be as specific as you can. The more specific you are, the more useful this plan will be.

The two areas where my most important work needs to happen right now:

What I notice when I look honestly at these areas — the patterns, the habits, the fears, the specific ways a setback has reached them:

The one person I will let fully in — and what I will ask them for, specifically:

The goal I am committing to — and whose face, whose love, whose loss, whose legacy is attached to it:

Three specific things I will do in the next thirty days:

First:

Second:

Third:

How I will know, ninety days from now, that something has shifted:

The one sentence I will return to when the work becomes difficult:

BOUNCING FORWARD

THREE KEYS TO KEEPING YOUR PLAN ALIVE

Return to it. Not to judge your progress but to learn from it. The plan you write today will need to change as you do — and that is not failure, it is evidence that you are moving.

Let it be imperfect. A plan that is attempted imperfectly is worth infinitely more than a plan that waits for perfect conditions. Begin with what you have.

Celebrate every genuine step. Not the performance of progress — the real kind. Every honest movement forward, however small, deserves to be acknowledged. It is evidence that the frozen is becoming the flowing. Let it count.

CONCLUSION

The Journey Is Yours

BOUNCING FORWARD

I want to end where we began. In memory of Hikmat. He was seventeen years old. He was full of life in the way that only the young can be — recklessly, beautifully, taking up more space in a room than seemed entirely fair. He had his whole horizon in front of him. I do not fully understand why his was taken. I have stopped trying to fully understand it. But I have learned — slowly, incompletely, with many setbacks along the way — to hold the question differently. Not “why did this happen?” But: “What does this ask of me?” That shift — from the question that has no answer to the question that demands one — is the whole of what this book has been trying to show you. The 4-Element Framework and the 4-Step Model are not magic. They are maps of territory I crossed the hard way, passed on to you in the hope that your crossing might be a little less disoriented, a little less alone, than mine was. They are tools. Use them. Adapt them. Discard what doesn’t fit and keep what does. What cannot be mapped — and what no framework can give you — is the most essential thing: your decision.

At some point in every crossing — every loss, every failure, every moment when the forest seems to close in — there is a choice. It is often quiet. It does not announce itself. But it is real, and it is yours. I made that choice in a hospital corridor in Amman in January 2008. I had no framework then, no model, no roadmap. I had grief, and faith, and somewhere beneath both of those, a refusal to let the worst moment of my life become its definition.

That refusal was the beginning of everything that came after. More than 1,200 playgrounds. 260 schools made safer. 1,800 hazardous roads identified and addressed. Thousands of families who will not receive a phone call at 2am — or who, if they do, will find that their roads are a little safer than they were before.

“The choice between staying in the darkness and turning toward the light. Between asking “why me?” and asking “what now?” Between bouncing back to who you were, and bouncing forward to who you are capable of becoming.”

Hikmat did not die for nothing. His name means wisdom. He earned it.

Now it is your turn. The road before you is yours to define. You have the compass. You have the path. You have, if you have read this far and allowed yourself to be honest, a clearer sense of where you stand and where you are going.

Go forward.

Not back to who you were before the storm. Forward to who you are when you have crossed it.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

BOUNCING FORWARD

Maher Kaddoura is a Jordanian with Palestinian roots, a Muslim educated in a Catholic school, and a man who has learned that our shared humanity matters more than the labels we carry. At fifteen, he explored Europe with a sleeping bag and a restless curiosity. He studied Civil Engineering at Nottingham University, then discovered his calling in management—working with the US Army in Jordan, helping establish Accenture’s Middle East practice, and building successful consulting firms of his own. In 2008, his seventeen-year-old son Hikmat was killed in a hit-and-run in Amman.

That devastation became his fuel. He founded the Hikmat Road Safety Program, which has since built over 1,200 playgrounds, marked 260 schools, and identified 1,800 dangerous locations on Jordan’s roads.

He has visited 90 countries and 250 cities. He has learned that unconditional giving doesn’t just help the recipient—it elevates the giver. And he has learned that setbacks, when met with purpose, become a catalyst for change. Hikmat’s name means wisdom in Arabic. He earned it.

“Setbacks, when met with purpose, become a catalyst for change — transforming personal pain into personal and community impact.”